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SM-1765-E
September 2024

YouTube CEO Susan Wojcicki: Can she deliver again? (A)

Isabel Villamor
Marta Elvira

Note: *The multimedia content of this document forms part of the case preparation; you can access it by clicking on the "Multimedia content" checkbox in the pdf file.*

On September 8, 2014, Susan Wojcicki, the CEO of YouTube since February that year, sat back in her chair after reading the breaking news. Facebook, the social media giant with 1.35 billion users globally, had just announced a strategic shift toward online videos. According to Facebook's product management director, "We're committed to making Facebook the best place to share, discover and watch videos."[1]

YouTube had led the online video-sharing space since its launch in February 2005. Developed by three former PayPal employees, the firm had grown astronomically, with its users watching 100 million videos on the site and uploading more than 65,000 new videos every day.[2] YouTube's success prompted Google to acquire it for $1.65 billion just a year after its creation.[3] By the time Wojcicki was named CEO, YouTube was uploading new content at a rate of 300 hours of video every minute and attracting 800 million unique users every month.[4] (See also **Exhibit A1**.)

Although Google did not provide detailed information on YouTube's financials, experts estimated its 2013 ad revenues at $5.6 billion, double that of 2012.[5] Despite its growing revenues, the firm had yet to break even.[6] Many interpreted Wojcicki's appointment as CEO as a move to finally make it profitable. The 16th employee at Google, she had faced a similar challenge when she joined the firm 24 years earlier. She had tremendous success with the launch of AdWords and AdSense, after which she became known as Google's main profit driver.[7]

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Fast-forward, and the competitive landscape had changed dramatically. Now that YouTube faced new competitive pressures in a fast-moving, volatile environment, would she be able to repeat her success and steer YouTube onto the road of profitability?

Arrival at Google

Wojcicki met Larry Page and Sergey Brin in 1998. She was both a newlywed and a recent MBA graduate with student loans to repay. To earn some extra income, she decided to rent out her garage to two recent Stanford graduates:

> They seemed nice. Their ideas sounded kind of crazy. Back then no one had heard of Larry Page and Sergey Brin or the new company with the funny name. Google? What? What does that mean? […] Once they moved in, we had late nights together in the garage, eating pizza and M&Ms, where they'd talk to me about how their technology could change the world. […] They made bold proclamations: 'We're going to organize the entire World Wide Web!' followed by 'Which day is recycling day?' And when I asked them how much experience they had to back this ambitious plan, they would say: 'Well, our combined age is almost 50.' And they were entering a competitive area. There were many well-funded famous search engines, famous at the time. […] I think I can say this now: I thought they were crazy.[8]

At the time, Wojcicki was working for Intel, a forerunner in the technology space. Page and Brin had asked her to join Google on numerous occasions, but she had always declined their offer. Until:

> One day something funny happened at work. I opened up my browser to look something up and it turned out that Google was down. There was an error page. And I sat there, and I couldn't get my work done because I realized that no other search service could find the information. I had become dependent on Google for doing my day-to-day work.[9]

Aware of the new search engine's potential, she decided to join the Google team:

> It turns out that finding information matters. It matters a lot to a lot of people, and accessing that information could instantly empower people across the globe. I decided I wanted to work for Google, which at the time also was crazy. With a mortgage to pay, student loans, I'd have to leave a comfortable job at a Fortune 500 company and work for the guys who lived in my garage at a start-up with no revenue, a handful of male employees, and, also, did I mention? I was pregnant. Now people thought I was the crazy one.[10]

Google's initial challenges

In 1999, just a year after Google's creation, Wojcicki was appointed marketing director. Her goal was to make Google the world's most widely used search engine.[11] The goal was far from easy- a budget of zero dollars and a target market of 'everybody.'" She started to partner with universities, requesting that they include a Google search bar in their websites.[12]

Wojcicki was named Google's senior vice president of advertising and commerce. In this role, she led advertising and analytic products, including AdWords, Google Analytics, and AdSense.[13] Advertising had become Google's primary source of income, growing from $7 million in 2001 to $59.62 billion by the time Wojcicki was appointed YouTube's CEO in 2014. In addition, she played a key role in two of Google's largest acquisitions: the $1.65 billion purchase of YouTube in 2006 and the $3.1 billion acquisition of DoubleClick in 2007.[14]

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During this time, she was also responsible for Google Video, which became obsolete with the YouTube acquisition.[15] Even though she was the project leader, she urged Page and Brin to buy the site after YouTube's figures had demolished the initial success of Google Video. She recalled:

> In 2004, there was no YouTube, and video on the Internet was rare. We were trying to figure out the right strategy for Google to be in the online video business. We were trying lots of different things, and nothing was getting traction. And one day, we decided we would allow users to upload their video to Google. We didn't tell users what would happen to their videos, and we had no idea what users would send to us. It was an experiment in every sense.[16]

Users from all over the world uploaded videos by the hundreds, which went into a Google database that was not accessible to end users. The team was still debating how to leverage and promote this new content, with no clear idea of how the product could be useful to users.

> So, a Friday night later, we got together and decided we'd watch some of these videos and see what we should do with this new experiment. We opened the first video and waited. It was of a purple furry puppet dancing and singing in Swedish. […] It was probably one of the first user-generated videos anyone had ever seen, and honestly, I had no idea what to think. But my kids knew what to think! They cheered, 'Play it again!' We played that video a lot. The videos were unusual. I hadn't seen anything like it before. They were interesting and funny and, more importantly, everyone wanted to see more of them.[17]

Realizing the potential of this experiment, the team started building a platform called Google Video. The number of videos uploaded and viewed grew every day. One of these videos reached one million views shortly after being uploaded. However, as Google Video began to take off, YouTube was launched and began to grow at breakneck speed. Suddenly, Google saw its initial success vanish. Fearful and confused, Wojcicki had to make a tough call—pretend that things were going all right and hope to catch up or recognize the failure and try to acquire YouTube.

> I had to go to our funders and our board and tell them the product that we had spent so much time building—Google Video—was losing, and we would have to spend over a billion and a half to fix the mistake. It was painful, it was public—it was one of the hardest decisions that I've had to make. People on my team quit in revolt. But acting fast, facing up to the problem, making a decision, buying YouTube, and then investing heavily in it was also one of the best decisions that we've ever made.
>
> If I hadn't owned up to my mistake and confronted failure fast instead of ignoring it, I would not be here today. […] When you fail, face your failure—face it head on, admit it, grow from it. When the world spins so fast, it means no one knows what the right answer is, and everyone will face failure. Ideas that were once "can't miss" missed. Companies that were surefire went down in flames. It's what you do when that happens that determines who ultimately succeeds and who does not. Failure is part of the process. It's where we learned the most, and it's what makes us who we are.[18]

Multimedia content

Johns Hopkins University 2014 Commencement Speaker: Susan Wojcicki, YouTube CEO

Source: Johns Hopkins University. YouTube.com.

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Google's distinct culture

Wojcicki, who had played a role in some of Google's best decisions, also helped develop the firm's distinct culture. Somehow, all the services that Google provides to their employees came from the early days in her garage.[19] The California-based company offered its employees free gourmet food, the best health insurance plan among US companies, the freedom to dedicate 20% of their time to their own projects, and even death benefits. [20]

As the first mother to work at Google, she was also responsible for the firm's family-friendly initiatives. Google provided a massive family benefits package, including $500 in "baby bonding bucks."[21] Thanks to such benefits, Google topped *Fortune* magazine's list of "The 100 Best Companies to Work For" every year since 2012. According to Wojcicki, the 2007 decision to increase paid maternity leave from 12 to 18 weeks enabled Google to halve the rate at which new mothers quit. "It may sound counterintuitive, but the research—and Google's own experience—shows a generous paid maternity leave actually increases retention," she wrote in a blog post for the *Huffington Post* on January 27, 2016. (See also Exhibit A2.)

The blog post had a tremendous impact in the US corporate arena and encouraged other top industry leaders, such as the Virgin Group, Netflix, and Amazon, to follow her lead. According to Wojcicki, such changes did more than just make new parents feel welcome in the workplace. Turnover was expensive, costing companies 20% or more of an employee's salary to hire a replacement, so they directly benefited by retaining and cultivating their talent pool.[22]

At the 2015 Fortune Brainstorm Tech conference in Aspen, Colorado, she was asked the one question that successful women cannot seem to escape: How did she balance entrepreneurialism and five children? Wojcicki had an answer ready: "I guess I like to create things," she said.[23] For her, work and motherhood were inextricably linked. She even associated each of her children with Google milestones:

Multimedia content

YouTube CEO Susan Wojcicki On Balancing Work And Family

Source: Today, 2014. YouTube.com.

Multimedia content

What does the Susan Wojcicki have to say about the future of YouTube?

Source: Fortune Magazine, 2015. YouTube.com.

> I joined Google when I was pregnant, so my oldest I've associated with Google. Then I worked with the team, and together we created AdSense after I came back from maternity leave (with my second). My third one, I associate with YouTube's acquisition. The fourth one is a DoubleClick baby, and the last one came right after I joined YouTube (as CEO).[24]

When talking to Today, Wojcicki reflected that "Not every life move, like a great job opportunity, will happen exactly when you want it to. Joining Google when I was four months pregnant was a bit of a leap, but sometimes you have to do the right thing for you right now."[25]

In her 2014 commencement speech at Johns Hopkins University in Baltimore, Maryland, Wojcicki shared the secrets of her personal and professional success:

> Life doesn't always present you with the perfect opportunity at the perfect time. Opportunities come when you least expect them or when you are not ready for them. Rarely are opportunities presented to you in the perfect way in a nice little box with a yellow bow on top. […]

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> Opportunities, the good ones, they're messy and confusing and hard to recognize. They're risky. They challenge you. But things happen so fast because our world is changing so much. You have to make decisions without perfect information. You have to make decisions based on the fact that the world is going to continue to change […]. It's those opportunities, the ones that make you believe in the future—those will be the best ones. Those are the ones that can change your life and those are the ones that can change the world.[26]

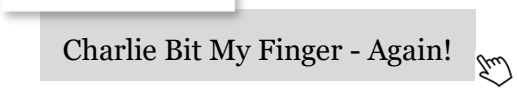
When Google bought YouTube, Wojcicki helped recruit more women. Among the initiatives that she and other industry leaders spearheaded to promote diversity in tech, Wojcicki launched an inspirational website aimed at attracting more girls to the sector.[27] Ranked number 12 on *Forbes* magazine's list of "The World's 100 Most Powerful Women" in 2014, Wojcicki said, "If women don't participate in tech, they are losing the chance to influence the largest economic and social shift of this century."[28]

Current challenges at YouTube

After Google's reorganization as Alphabet, YouTube remained a part of Google with Wojcicki at the helm, drawing over a billion monthly visitors and valued at $70 billion.[29]

Seemingly overnight, YouTube became a universal platform for people to entertain, dance, sing, laugh and learn. The video-sharing site also launched celebrities such as Justin Bieber, bolstered companies such as Gore (of Gore-Tex fabric fame), and contributed to political change in countries such as Egypt. It also shaped popular culture, such as the viral video *Charlie Bit My Finger - Again.* On a corporate level, YouTube disrupted global industries in a way similar to what Google did when it launched. "Google is pretty big now but I look at YouTube and I feel like it's Google 10 years ago. I see the potential for it to grow,"[30] Wojcicki recalled. "As it reminds me of the initial stages of Google, I found myself asking

Multimedia content



Source: HDCYT, 2007. Charlie bit my finger - again! YouTube.com.

Multimedia content



Source: Fortune Magazine, 2014. YouTube.com.

"What did I do in Google then? I think a lot of how I did things, what I learned, and how to do it now: hiring the right people, giving them the right direction, and setting the right priorities."[31] As at Google years earlier, she had to move from actual revenues to positive profits. (See Exhibit A3.) According to Google CEO Larry Page, Wojcicki had a "healthy disregard for the impossible."[32]

Upon her arrival at YouTube, Wojcicki was charged with building a business by expanding the site and luring TV advertisers. Her innovations during her first year included subscriptions, original content, and virtual reality. "It's definitely different from the ads role, for sure. But I love the creativity of the YouTube role," she said in a 2016 interview with Britain's *Financial Times*[33].

Wojcicki reached out to YouTube talent and worked hard to understand their needs and aspirations. The attendees at a VidCon event in California, including industry executives, YouTube video producers, and fans, highlighted her close connection to the YouTube community.[34] Asked in 2016 by the *Financial Times* how she got along with YouTubers like the

Swedish gamer PewDiePie, whose "Bro Army" fan base was 43.6 million at the time (54.8 million subscribers as of April 2017), Wojcicki responded that there were little jokes, such as "Don't turn off my channel."[35]

Competition

YouTube experimented with video—from its new subscription service Red, where viewers could pay $9.99 a month to watch without advertising—to its Red Originals series.[36] In the process, Wojcicki was explicit about the company's desire to reinvent TV. Even though YouTube's streaming services had lower perceived value than those of its competitors Netflix, Amazon, and Hulu (see Exhibit A3), Wojcicki was confident about YouTube's move to provide content. Wojcicki had a clear vision: "We're going to enable it to be global, social, and across divides, and on demand."[37] In February 2017, she translated this vision into YouTube TV, a $35-a-month TV service that packaged several channels from broadcast and cable networks (Fox, CBS, and NBC).

Hollywood and the music industry also viewed YouTube as a rival. The movie industry responded to this challenge by investing in multichannel online networks that showcased its stars. Yet, the 2017 Oscars ceremony showcased the growing influence of video streaming platforms, with Amazon Studios taking home two Oscars and Netflix securing a win in the documentary short subject category.[38]

Music labels vilified YouTube, complaining that its online streaming ate into their music video margins and that user uploads infringed upon copyright laws. In her 2016 *Financial Times* interview, Wojcicki paused at the mention of YouTube's problems with the music industry, as tense negotiations over new licensing deals approached. She preferred to focus instead on what she saw as fresh opportunities: "The ad business, for example, is new for the music industry. I think the advantage that we see is that now they can generate revenue from all of their users." [39]

Copyright was only part of the problem that Wojcicki had with the music industry. Traditional music labels were learning fast and devising their strategies accordingly. For instance, Vevo was developing a new business model. Erik Huggers, Vevo's president and CEO, claimed, "We are a specialty store for music. YouTube is a very successful flea market."[40] Vevo posed a significant threat to YouTube's music content.

With Facebook emerging as an increasingly prominent viral video competitors, YouTube needed to innovate—and fast. The online video channel tried to empower creators to build immersive 3D content. "We want to enable all of you to chart this new frontier," Wojcicki said.[41] She told the *Financial Times* that virtual reality (VR) could be "really compelling," but it would start by being a novelty, not the norm. "I think VR can really transport us in a way that a trip can or going to a movie can and I believe it'll be a really important part of storytelling in the future."[42]

To illustrate her point, she cited the Disney film *Frozen*. The film won two Oscars and amassed $1.3 billion in box office revenue.[43] According to Wojcicki, "The significant factor that Disney did was to embrace YouTube."[44] Right after *Frozen* was released, fans started uploading their versions of the song "Let It Go."[45] Wojcicki recalled:

> *Frozen* has uploaded the video in 70 languages, and it has been viewed almost 1.5 billion times. Whatever industry you embrace, you will face change. It will make you nervous. It's hard. People don't like change. It can have hard and real consequences for individuals and companies. On the other hand, change keeps happening – there is new technology, consumers make new choices, and business and services need to adapt. It feels unusual. Our instinct is to fight it. But we need to embrace it. We need to *let it go*.[46]

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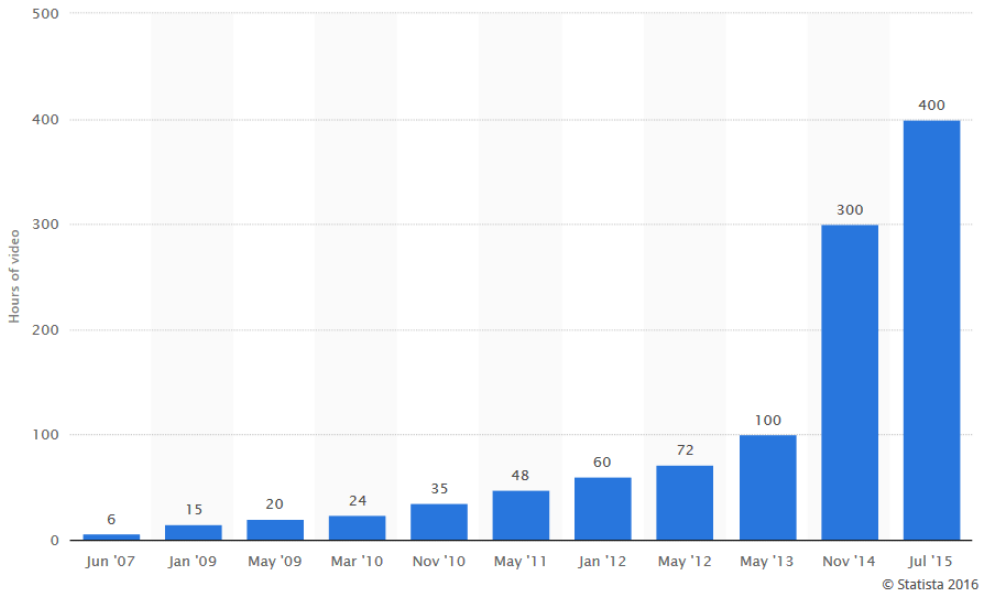
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Sometimes, she was asked whether she had ever thought about setting up her own YouTube channel. It was probably the last thing on Wojcicki's mind after Facebook announced its decision to enter the video-sharing space. Faced with intense internal pressure to repeat her prior success at Google and make YouTube profitable, coupled with the external challenges of increased volatility, she had bigger fish to fry.

Exhibit A1

YouTube content and advertising growth

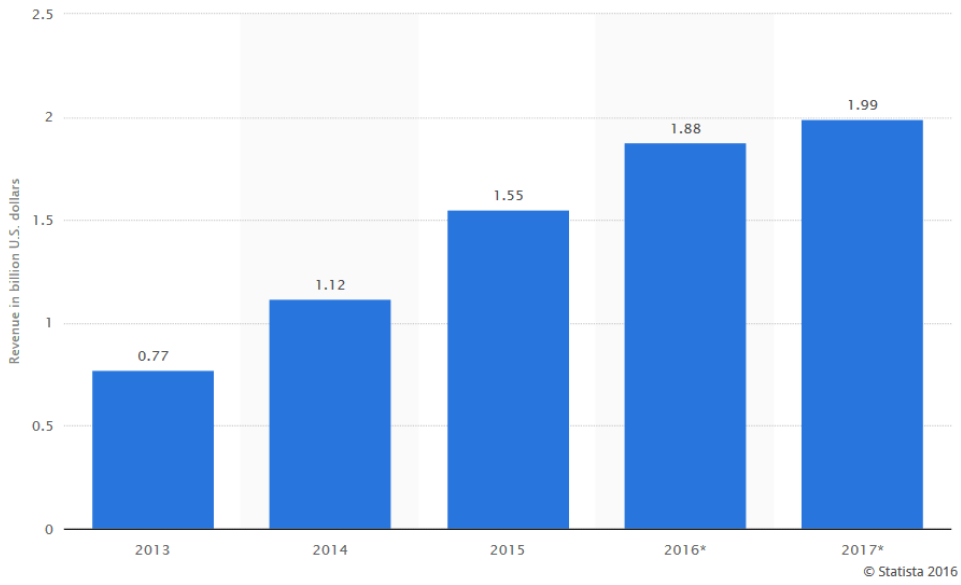
Hours of video uploaded to YouTube every minute as of July 2015



Additional Information:
Worldwide; YouTube; June 2007 to July 2015

Sources:
YouTube; Tubefilter

Net video advertising revenues of YouTube in the United States from 2013 to 2017 (in billion U.S. dollars)



Additional Information:
United States; eMarketer; Google; 2013 to 2015

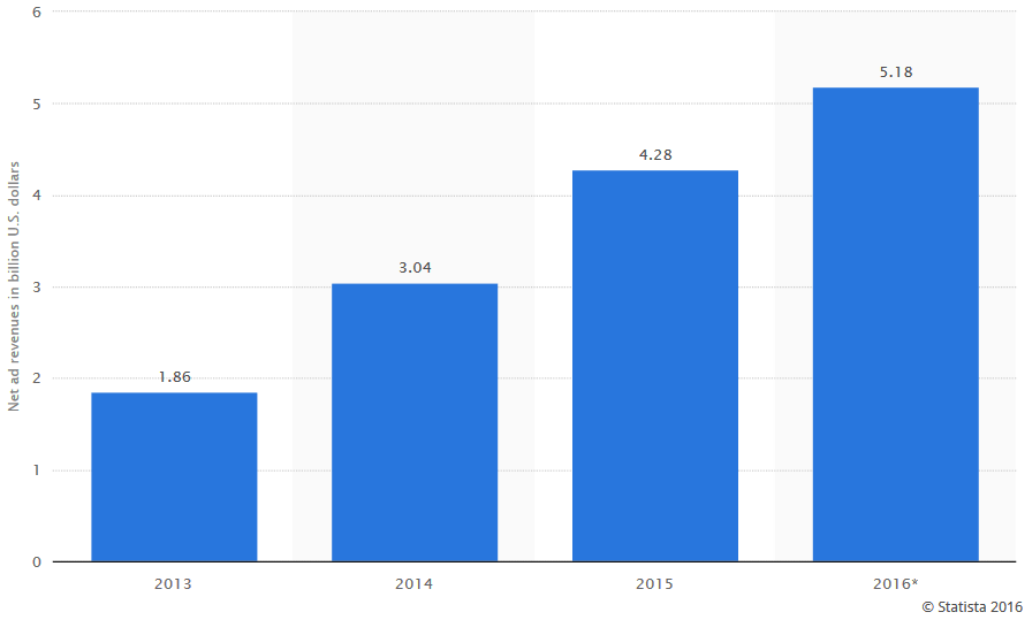
Sources:
eMarketer; Google

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Exhibit A1 (continued)

Worldwide net advertising revenues of YouTube from 2013 to 2016 (in billion U.S. dollars)



Additional Information:
Worldwide; eMarketer; Google; 2013 to 2015; all values are estimates

Sources:
eMarketer; Google

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Exhibit A2

Wall Street Journal article by Susan Wojcicki: "Paid Maternity Leave Is Good for Business"

Wall Street Journal article by Susan Wojcicki: "Paid Maternity Leave Is Good for Business"

When we increased paid leave at Google to 18 weeks, the rate at which new mothers left fell by 50%

By Susan Wojcicki Dec. 16, 2014, 6:49 p.m. ET

I was Google's first employee to go on maternity leave. In 1999, I joined the startup that founders Larry Page and Sergey Brin had recently started in my garage. I was four months pregnant. At the time the company had no revenue and only 15 employees, almost all of whom were male. Joining a startup pregnant with my first child was risky, but Larry and Sergey assured me I'd have their support.

This month, I'll go on maternity leave once again—my fifth time—joining the nearly 5,000 women who have done so since I joined Google. And though I'm now CEO of YouTube (which is owned by Google), I'll be entitled to the same benefits as every single woman at the company who has a baby: 18 weeks of paid maternity leave.

Having experienced how valuable paid maternity leave is to me, my family and my career, I never thought of it as a privilege. But the sad truth is that paid maternity leave is rare in America, and the U.S. lags behind the rest of the world in providing for the needs of pregnant women and new mothers.

According to a survey released in May by the United Nations' International Labor Organization, the U.S. is the *only* country in the developed world that doesn't offer government-mandated paid maternity leave. Every other developed country offers paid maternity leave benefits through social-security programs, so businesses don't have to shoulder the entire cost. Paid maternity leave isn't just a First World perk—the U.S. is one of only two countries of the 185 surveyed that does not offer it. The other is Papua New Guinea.

There are two ways women in America can receive paid maternity leave. They can work for a generous employer that provides it as a benefit. Or they can live in one of the few states—California, Hawaii, New Jersey, New York and Rhode Island—that have publicly funded paid-maternity-leave laws. According to the Labor Department, that patchwork of corporate and state benefits covers only 12% of private workers. Low-wage earners, those in the bottom income quartile, have it much worse: only 5% get any paid maternity leave. The Family and Medical Leave Act of 1993 is a step in the right direction, but it is unpaid and doesn't cover half the working women in the U.S.

In study after study, the ILO and other labor and health organizations have shown how harmful a lack of paid maternity leave can be for mothers and their babies. Many times when faced with insufficient maternity leave, mothers choose to drop out of the workforce, leading to a considerable loss of income during a woman's most productive years. Or it can force a woman back to work too quickly, with adverse effects on her and her child's health.

A quarter of all women in the U.S. return to work fewer than 10 days after giving birth, leaving them less time to bond with their children, making breast-feeding more difficult and increasing their risk of postpartum depression. According to the American Academy of Pediatrics, suboptimal breast-feeding causes higher rates of infant illness and hospitalization that cost billions of dollars annually.

Paid maternity leave is also good for business. After California instituted paid medical leave, a survey in 2011 by the Center for Economic and Policy Research found that 91% of employers said the policy either boosted profits or had no effect. They also noted improved productivity, higher morale and reduced turnover.

That last point is one we've seen at Google. When we increased paid maternity leave to 18 from 12 weeks in 2007, the rate at which new moms left Google fell by 50%. (We also increased paternity leave to 12 weeks from seven, as we know that also has a positive effect on families and our business.) Mothers were able to take the time they needed to bond with their babies and return to their jobs feeling confident and ready. And it's much better for Google's bottom line—to avoid a costly turnover, and to retain the valued expertise, skills and perspective of our employees who are mothers.

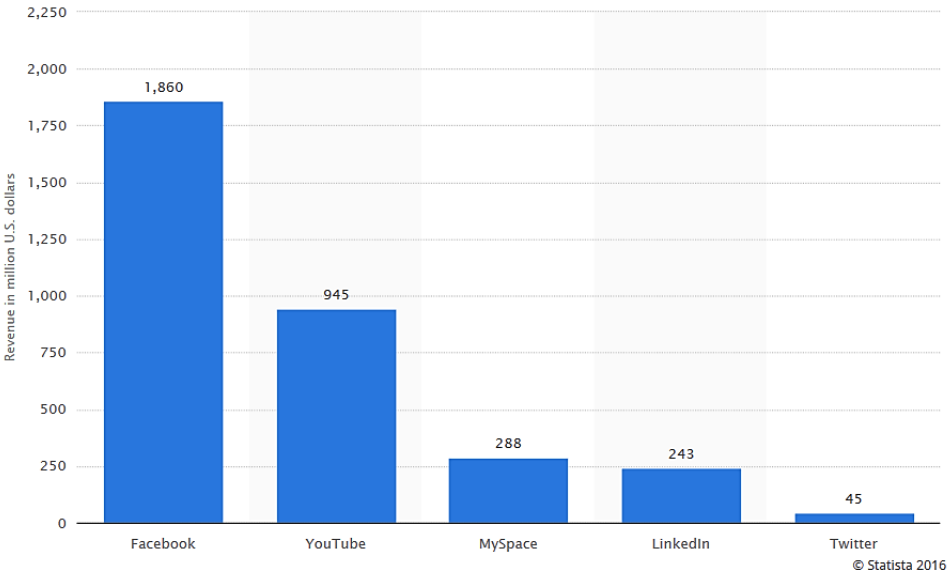
Best of all, mothers come back to the workforce with new insights. I know from experience that being a mother gave me a broader sense of purpose, more compassion and a better ability to prioritize and get things done efficiently. It also helped me understand the specific needs and concerns of mothers, who make most household spending decisions and control more than $2 trillion of purchasing power in the U.S.

I've been lucky to have the support of a company that values motherhood as much as Google. And I've been lucky to live in a state like California that supports working mothers. But support for motherhood shouldn't be a matter of luck; it should be a matter of course. Paid maternity leave is good for mothers, families, and business. America should have the good sense to join nearly every other country in providing it.

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Exhibit A3
Data on YouTube competitors

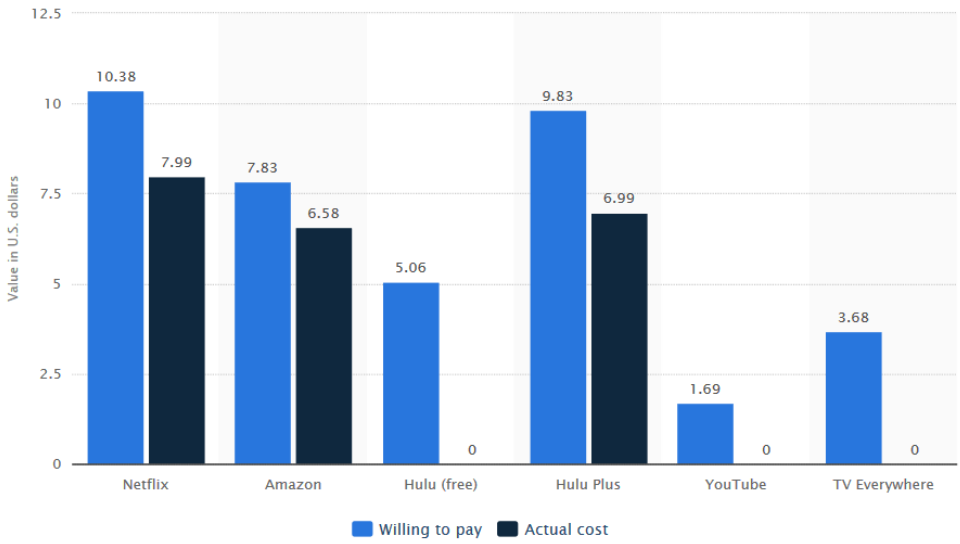
Worldwide revenues as of 2010 (in million U.S. dollars)



Additional Information:
Worldwide; 2010

Sources:
eMarketer; TechCrunch; The Next Web

Value in U.S. dollars as of 2010 (in U.S. dollars)



Additional Information:
GfK

Source:
GfK

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